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Earl Watkins

Drummer Earl Watkins was born in San Francisco on January 29, 1920. Since the mid-1940s he has been a major figure in the Bay area jazz scene and is well known for his association with Earl Hines and Kid Ory. Earl played an instrumental role in the 1960 merger of the white and black musicians' union in San Francisco and continues to maintain an important role in the city as a musician and union executive.

Earl was interviewed in San Francisco, California on August 7, 2002 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I am filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive today in San Francisco and I'm very pleased to have Earl Watkins with me.

EW: My pleasure.

MR: And your name seems to be synonymous with music here in San Francisco as I discovered in talking to a number of people out here on the phone — they always mentioned your name. "You better talk to Earl" they said. So it's a great pleasure to be here. I have a feeling that San Francisco has changed a lot since your youth.

EW: Well yes. I'm a native born San Franciscan, I was born in 1920, January the 29th, and there have been many, many, many changes. Everything. Our skyline has changed, it's been Manhattanized, our transportation system, which used to be the best in the country, we're having problems with it. We went from all electric streetcars and cable cars and we went to buses and we do have light rail now but it's in trouble, our municipal railway. We have an underground, which we never had before, then we have of course the BART, that's here of course — well I'm getting ahead of myself. We have two bridges which we didn't have before. When I was growing up we had ferry boats, yeah, we rode the ferry. There was a ferry to Sausalito, there was a ferry to Oakland, there was a ferry to Berkeley, and there was a ferry that ran to Richmond and from Richmond there was a ferry that ran over to San Rafael. So now we have the Golden Gate Bridge, which leads you into Marin County, we have the Bay Bridge from San Francisco to Oakland, then we have another bridge from Richmond to San Rafael, the Richmond-San Rafael Bridge. And now also we have a San Mateo Bridge, that's a bridge from Hayward to San Mateo. But that bridge — I think that's been there — for as long as I can remember that's been there. Then they have another one they call the Dunbarton Bridge. And it runs, you go further south past Hayward and it's down near Mountain View and then you cross over and it's more — I guess it's more like a land bridge more than above the water. So now also we have different districts here. We have the — well naturally downtown, the Nob Hill, we have the South of Market, you've got the Western Addition — that's where I

grew up — and you've got the Richmond District, that's going out to the beach say from Presidio Avenue west and that's on the north side of Geary Blvd. Then you have the Sunset District. Now the Sunset District would be beyond our deYoung museum in the past, that would be going west, and on the opposite side of the park, the south side of the park, all of that area. Now that area, when I was growing up, was sand dunes. They had sand dunes. You had streets but you had sand dunes. And when you'd take people out, if you were going to teach someone how to drive a vehicle, you'd take them out there to the sand dunes, so if the car got out of a control why there would be no damage. Of course after World War II then there was this big building boom, and so this fella Doelger, he built — he developed the Sunset and also the area where San Francisco State is, Stonestown, Daly City. So there's just been all kinds of change. And of course our population — the population, it's not necessarily San Francisco although we've had a big increase here, but the Bay area see, now San Francisco is very small, we're like on the tip of the peninsula and we can only go—

MR: Right. You can only go so far.

EW: Yeah you can only go up, like New York, huh? And the traffic. Now before, when I was growing up, very few people had cars. Very few of the people that I knew and my family knew, and also the people who were considered to be the business people, maybe corporate owners at that time. They had chauffeurs. Chauffeurs was a big thing. My dad was a chauffeur.

MR: I see.

EW: And that was considered to be a pretty good job.

MR: I was going to ask what your parents did for a living.

EW: Yeah. And my mother, she was a housewife, she stayed home. And what happened, see most of the chauffeurs, they hired colored chauffeurs. A large percentage of the chauffeurs were colored chauffeurs. That was considered a good job. In later years, especially during the depression, see what happened, a lot of oriental people came in, the Japanese, and they would hire the husband and wife. They would stay on the premises. The wife would do the cooking and the house cleaning and the husband would do the gardening and general clean up, butlering, and chauffeur. So that was during the depression.

MR: So African-American chauffeurs found themselves out of work?

EW: Oh yeah.

MR: That's really interesting.

EW: But now also, before the war and during the depression our black or African-American population was comparatively small. I think the different statistics I've read place it around five thousand people. So you knew a lot of the people. Some by name, some just

by seeing them in a district where you lived or in your travels bumping into different people, seeing familiar faces, and then of course as a kid the adults knew you, you couldn't get away with anything because the adults, they would admonish you, many times on the spot or else when you got home the telephone had rung and so we had to be on our best behavior. And most of the African-American population lived in the Western Addition. We had a few that lived out on the Avenues, a few lived out in the Mission District, a few in the Marina, but in the main they lived in the Western Addition. And we all went to school, and the schools were mixed/integrated so you had a chance to get a good education. And so during the war why there was a migration of the people and they needed them because the war industry sprung up practically overnight. And the Bay area, oh man we had all sorts of industries scattered out through the whole Bay area. Kaiser Shipbuilding, there was steel, I've forgotten the names, steel companies, machine shops, oh there were just all sorts of businesses that were contracted to help with the war effort. Now I worked at the Navy Supply Depot, see, before I went in the service, when that opened up. And then also when I went in the service they put us on leave immediately so I went to work at a valve company that made valves. And I don't know whether they were for the ships or for the tanks, but anyhow they made valves. I did that for about two months before I got called to Active Duty.

MR: Can I ask how old you were when you got called up?

EW: I was 22, yeah 22 years old. Let's see around June or July, the Navy sent a Chief Musician out to our union meetings. See we used to have separate union meetings. A black union, we would meet in Oakland at the Elks building there. They had a building with a bar upstairs and there was quite a building, a very nice building. And we would hold our meetings there. Because we were a subsidiary. And we weren't allowed access to the Local 6 musicians headquarters. But anyhow the Navy, they sent a Chief out to recruit black musicians to be stationed on the shore, given shore duty. So it was an offer you couldn't refuse, because I was 1A. And so—

MR: In your head, were you thinking it's this or perhaps the infantry?

EW: Oh yeah. We were all thinking that. Everybody was thinking out there in the mud in the trenches. We were all thinking that. And also this was a chance, I was pretty raw, very raw as a musician. I had only been in the local, I joined in '37 so I'd been in the local five years, and my experience — I was kind of limited. I had done little dance jobs playing with small groups. But we'll probably get around to that as we go through my musical history. So I jumped at the chance. And it was a Godsend because in that band you had a lot of real stalwarts and real artists. You had Marshall Royal was our musical director. Marshall ended up being the lead alto player for Count Basie, and then when he left Count Basie he did studio work in Los Angeles and he was one of the most sought after

lead alto players in the country. His brother, Ernie Royal, outstanding trumpet player who ended up in New York doing studio work, but they all were with the original Lionel Hampton band, the band that made "Flying Home." Vernon Alley of course, Mister Music, he was in the band, Wilbert Baranco, who is mentioned in the Leonard Feather, who was a very fine musician/pianist/singer and arranger. Wilbert, during the WPA days, he had been connected with the music project in San Francisco, and he wrote for everything, orchestra, voices, strings. And prior to that he had been on the road with — oh what the heck, the name slips but it will come to me in a moment — but Wilbert was a very, very fine pianist and arranger. Then we had Ernie Royal, we had Herman Grimes, a fine trumpet player who had played in Los Angeles with Les Hite and some of the other bands. Ike Bill out of Kansas City who grew up with Basie and all the Kansas City bunch. Trombones Dan Hamilton, Frasier Scott and Ralph Bledsoe, who was a very, very fine arranger and trombonist. He later became a dentist. And on saxophones you had Curtis Lowe, baritone. Curtis and I, well we knew one another like I say from 1937. Curtis later, after the Navy band, we went together around here and then he left and went with Lionel Hampton and then he was back and forth with Lionel Hampton and Curtis ended up working at the musicians' union at our Local 669 as the secretary. Then when we merged he was given a job as assistant to Local 6 and they welcomed him because he had gained so much knowledge of Federation rules and he was a marvel with wage scales and things. Then we had Q. Dullis Martin, he played tenor sax, clarinet and arranged. He had been with the Les Hite band in Los Angeles and also with the Benny Carter band. And Q, he could write arrangements just like you were writing a letter. Then we had Jerome Richardson, he was on alto and flute. Then we had Jackie Kelson. He's now the lead alto player with the new Basie Band. Yeah, Jack Kelson. And Andy Anderson on tenor sax. Andy was from Cleveland, a very fine saxophone player. He didn't achieve any really notoriety or didn't become a big name but he was an outstanding player. Now this is our Naval Pre-Flight band. Benny Sexton played guitar, an excellent guitarist, and I already mentioned Vernon on the bass. Then we had Buddy Collette. Buddy Collette was in the band. And Marshall wanted him to be in the number one dance band. But Buddy declined and so what happened, out of the 45 men, Marshall took the cream. So Buddy took the other guys, and whipped them into a band. We were the Rhythm Bombardiers, and I've forgotten for the moment what Buddy called his band. Anyhow he whipped them into such good shape that they would go out and play for dances at the USO on the various places, just like we would, as the number one band. But they were the names, and people who went on to become further in their career. We had other fellows in there, but — out of 45 men — and their names slip me for the moment. But anyhow that's what happened with our Navy, with my Navy experience. And we spent

three years at St. Mary's College. See we went in, when they called us we were all put on temporary leave when they first recruited us. Then when they told us okay it's time, then we got on the train and this was in 1945 [sic] around October, maybe the first of October, yeah, got on the train, the Western Pacific, and took off for Chicago. Well there was a jam session going on where the guys had their books out and they were having jam sessions on the train. Because we had a private car. And they had one compartment in it, that's where the Chief stayed. And so the guys made so much noise. One day the Chief said, "Okay, no more sessions." Because it was a three day trip. So I think after about the middle of the second day, so we traveled and we went to oh Omaha and Salt Lake City, Denver, and finally we landed in Chicago. So we got off the train in Chicago. And there we are standing on the platform, so we had to go out to what they called the North Side, because that's where the Great Lakes training station was. So we were all standing on the platform. So then this truck came and took us out to the Great Lakes. Now they had two separate camps. Camp Robert Smalls, that's the black camp. And then the Great Lakes Naval Training Station, that was the white side. So we had to wait, I don't know, but we had to wait for something. So we're standing up there in our California clothes and that wind, you know that Chicago wind, whoooo — it would go right up your pants leg you know. So anyhow, but finally they got us inside and they found a barracks for us. Assigned us bunks and everything. And they didn't have enough bunks. See they have some bunks and hammocks. So what they did with me, see I'm W, I'm way down on the list because they process you alphabetically. So see they didn't have any bunks. So what they did they said well one of our — we've got some of the fellas who were on leave and you can sleep in this fella's bunk until he comes back. It turned out to be Clark Terry's bunk. And this is 1942, and he hadn't made a name for himself and we didn't know one another. But when he came back naturally I had to give up the bunk. So I mentioned that to him when he was here at one of our clubs a few years back. And I had a picture of that band, I don't know what I did with it, but I had a picture of the band, the Great Lakes Band, I had a picture of that. I don't know where I got it from but it was a copy. I don't know where I got it from. I think I gave it to him.

MR: Boy that name has come up a lot, that place near Chicago where all the servicemen—

EW: Camp Robert Smalls. And their ship's company band was a dynamite band. Clark Terry was in it, Osie Johnson the drummer was in it, Willie Smith was in it for a short time. They say he got out on a Section 8 so I guess he put on a pretty good act. Yeah. And from there he went to Charlie Spivak's band because the white bands were starting to integrate. So anyhow, at Great Lakes that's when we got all the uniforms and everything and then the Chief, we had to learn how to march in formation, make your right turn, your left

turn, do your about face and we had one guy, a real tall handsome guy, they made him the band leader.

MR: Yeah. With the baton kind of?

EW: Yeah. And so they would have happy hours. And when they would have happy hours you would have the entertainment that would come in. One happy hour they had the Jimmy Lunceford Orchestra.

MR: Oh my.

EW: Oh man. And they were hot then. You know, 1942, they were hot. They had all these wonderful arrangements and they were a first class band. Willie Smith was in that band, along with Gerald Wilson and —

MR: Snooky Young maybe?

EW: Snooky was in it, yeah. Joe Thomas. Oh and Jessie Crawford the drummer, outstanding. So that was one time. And so the Commander, the fellow who was in charge of the music program, was Eddie Peabody, the banjo player. And he would, during the happy hours, he would always perform. And he was outstanding. And then of course one of the requirements for being released from training was you had to parade in front of him and do your maneuvers and everything. But he was a great guy you know. Because he was a performer. He wasn't strictly Navy. He had been in World War I and so he was in the Reserves, so through the Reserves he just kept increasing his rank. So he was a Commander. And so anyhow what happened, our Chief, he was trying to get us out of there as soon as possible because the Chief from the ship's company band at Great Lakes, he was trying to raid the band. Because he had Ernie Royal, who was on the "Flying Home" high notes — Ernie was noted for high notes plus he was a fine player. Of course Marshall — because the fellas would have jam sessions. And the other Chief would be there watching to see who could do what. So they were trying to raid our band. So our Chief, he was old Navy. He had an armful of gold stripes you know, indicating like the service gold, so that meant that he was 1A, you know, never had any disciplinary problems or anything. So anyhow he got us out of there and then we came back to California. And on December 1st — because we spent Thanksgiving there at Great Lakes. We had a turkey dinner. And then of course on the train coming back there was no jam session. Because we were Navy then, oh yes. So anyhow we came back and we went there to St. Mary's and then we were lucky because see besides being stationed there you lived off the base. So that's one of the reasons I guess they recruited us from this area. So we were given quarters and subsistence, besides our Navy pay — what was it $66 a month — and they took out $12 for family allowance if you were married.

MR: They took it out and did what with it?

EW: They added to it and sent it to your dependent.

MR: They sent $12 a month?

EW: Well they added to it with quarters and subsistence I think it amounted to around oh I think around $87 or $92 a month or something like that. But see in 1942 for crying out loud, what was the rent? People were paying — oh heck they weren't paying very much rent. Because you had price and wage controls. So that was to prevent gouging. And so I think I was living with my in-laws but then when I got the apartment I think it was — was it $27.50 a month? Something like that. For a one bedroom duplex. So anyhow we lived off the base. And the fellas that had cars, they would have carpools. And since they had to use the car to get to and from work why they could get gas coupons. So what happened, Marshall started organizing the band, putting the band together. And for me, boy, it was really something. Because I had never been in company that fast before. So gradually I came around, you know, gradually. I started taking lessons from Herb Sanford, he was one of my teachers. He was an old Vaudevillian and played in the dime dances, oh yeah, and he played percussion. He played marimba and the vibraphone as well. And so anyhow over a period of time the band shaped up. And we would, besides playing a dance every Sunday for the cadets, see the USO would bring hostesses out and they'd recruit them from the universities and from the different servicemens' associations. They would recruit the young ladies and they would come out to the base and they had a huge drill hall with a beautiful wooden floor and they had a bandstand there and we would play every Sunday for dances for the cadets. Then we would record once a week for the OWI, Office of War Information, and they would set up a telephone and we'd do a remote, and we were remote, and then the recording would take place in the city. And then you could come over here to an office they had down on Sutter and Kearney and you could go upstairs and listen to the playback. And these records, they would be broadcast overseas to the Twelfth Naval District.

MR: Were these the V-disks?

EW: They weren't really V-disks, because I think the V-disks were smaller. These were large glass. They ended up large glass disks, and we would go down there. We recorded two for another — what was it, the Office of War Information and something else, someone else we recorded for. So we could have done V-disks because they were very popular. I know I think the Glenn Miller overseas band I think they did V-disks, and so many of the other service bands. But with us it turned out that we were considered as a top rated band in the Twelfth Naval District, which was a great honor. Because here you had — Artie Shaw was in the South Pacific, he had a band, and when he got out Sam Donahue took it over. And Davy Tough was in that band and it was all full of Los Angeles studio musicians. Then the Coast Guard here had an excellent band. Then Pete Rugulo was in an Army band, they had an Army band and Pete Rugulo was their arranger, and where else?

Well they had bands all over the place you know. So they picked our band. Now I don't know why. I found out in later years that the Captain of our station, he was somehow related to somebody, one of the Admirals here in the Twelfth Naval District so I don't know whether he had the pull or what, but then of course we always met the challenge. Every week we'd have at least three tunes. And special arrangements. And also at that time during the war this area was one of the greatest areas for dance bands. That Oakland auditorium, Lionel Hampton used to pull seven thousand people, seventy-five hundred people. One of the times in the forties when Cab Calloway came out to do a picture, I think it was "Cabin in the Sky," but he came up to our Golden Gate Theater to see the band, just to do the Golden Gate Theater truly they had Vaudeville and they featured name bands. But this has to do with Cab Calloway and the dance, the fact that of showing how this area was such a marvelous draw for dancers. Cab Calloway did the theater and then he played the Oakland auditorium. They had ten thousand people and the fire department closed the doors. And the people were milling around outside. I was one of them. And somebody opened the side door and I slipped in.

MR: All right.

EW: But that's what would happen here. See before the war, we didn't have that many big bands. You had Vaudeville, but the only time you'd really have a big band would be when they came out to make a movie, see cause the transportation costs were prohibitive I guess at that time. So when there would be a picture, then the band, they would come right up the coast, up to Seattle and then back East again. The Glenn Miller band, they came here, I saw them over at Sweet's Ballroom. They did a couple of pictures here. One was something about Sun Valley.

MR: Sun Valley Serenade or something like that.

EW: Yes, something like that. And Charlie Barnet's band, I got to see them. As a matter of fact, Charlie Barnet, he was out here in 1939. So I guess he did a picture then. Because he played the old Palomar, before the Palladium in Los Angeles. And so the Palomar had Charlie Barnet, and see they used to broadcast and I would listen to them on the radio. Artie Shaw's band was there, Buddy Rich was with him — I would listen to them, then Barnet's band. Now Barnet, his closing night, he closed and Count Basie was supposed to open the following week. It would have been the first time a colored band had ever played the Palomar. But Basie was hot you know. So what happened? The place caught fire. And all of Barnet's instruments were burned and the library. And what happened, they came up to Sweet's Ballroom with all brand new instruments and I don't know where they got the library from or if they played it by ear, but I went to see that band. And of course that's kind of like history. And with Basie, now he was in Los Angeles so they booked him in some of the places there and then they brought him up here to

perform at our Exposition. They were at Exposition 1939 World Exposition at Treasure Island. And I was blessed because I was in it all night. I got to go there and see that. Benny Goodman came up, by then Krupa and Harry James had left him but he had Nick Fatool on drums and Fletcher Henderson was playing piano. And that was a kind of memorable because our show was at the Golden Gate Theater. And Goodman was at Treasure Island. So that meant you taxied between the two. And I don't know how we did it because we didn't have any money. In 1939 who had any money? But we would go see Goodman and then we'd go to the theater, because you know Buddy Rich was with him at the time. And even then, on records, Buddy Rich really impressed me on records because of his fire and his solos. I didn't realize at that time there was more to him than appeared. He played for the band. He knew just exactly what to play, I don't care what the song was, I don't care what the style was, he had an instinct. But of course part of it too was exposure. Because he grew up in Vaudeville. And he used to watch, from what they say, he learned from watching all of the Vaudeville drummers throughout the country. And these guys, you know, they had all kinds of sound effects, because before the talkies you know they had—

MR: Juggling and all that kind of stuff.

EW: Oh yeah. Making the thunder noise when on the screen there was a thunder. And the rain noises. And then of course when you had everything, your juggling acts and your dog acts and they had to do everything, with the whistle — whoop and the rolls, that sounded like paper tearing, you know, really fine, symphony style rolls. But so Rich, and in later years I realized that he was just more than a noisemaker. This guy was — he knew exactly what the band needed or what the musical occasion called for to play, and the act, he could play any act. Because he was a tap dancer himself. And he had seen all the acts. He had grown up with all the different routines. But anyhow so back and forth we were, back and forth. So that was the — and with Basie's, then the guys stayed here. So although I didn't get to know them, friends of mine, they really got to know the fellas in the Basie band. And I was underage too so I couldn't go in the night clubs. Couldn't hang out in the bars, or the watering holes.

MR: And in those dance situations, was the audience different for the white bands or for the black bands, or was it pretty mixed?

EW: In the thirties, the late thirties, even up to the forties before, in Oakland, at Sweet's Ballroom, that's where most of the fellas went because that's where the big bands would make their appearance, the dance halls they had here they were more like steady jobs. They were regular Saturday night dances, some of them ran four and five nights a week. They didn't cater to minorities, you know, Asians or African-Americans, no. They wouldn't let you in.

MR: They wouldn't let you in.

EW: Yeah, see. And Sweet's Ballroom, they had a colored night and a white night. Sunday night was white night, Monday night was the colored night. And if you went down there—

MR: But was it the same band?

EW: Same band. When Lunceford's band came through, white night, colored night. Basie's band came through, white night, colored night. Glenn Miller band came through, white night, colored night. Louis came through with a group, colored night, white night. Fats Waller, colored night and a white night. But then when the war came, suddenly the population increased and people were working 24 hours a day in three 8-hour shifts. So people had plenty of money and they could go out and they didn't mind, see, if you had to leave the dance early to go to work. But what happened, it expanded so and Sweet's, with a 2,500 person capacity, they couldn't handle the crowds. So Sweet's turned over the colored bands to a fella named John Burton, lived in Berkeley. And John became a promoter. And so then they started using the Oakland auditorium. And so then the bands would come to the Oakland auditorium. And they would draw. They would draw, like I say, Hampton, he'd draw 7,500 people, Basie over 5,000, Nat King Cole came in with just four people — the place was packed. Then I saw — who else did I see there at the Oakland auditorium during the war. See the USO shows would come here. And many of them had bands from back east with them. So that took care of the transportation costs. So when the show got out here, the bands then, the different promoters would book them up and down the coast. And I would go to the Oakland auditorium every time a big band would show up, I'd be right there. Because when I was a teenager I collected records. And so I would have all these different records of these different Eastern bands, and this was my chance to see them in person. So I saw the Andy Kirk band, and you know Pha Terrell, the singer, they were — oh man, they were a top flight band. I saw another band at the Kershner Gardens, which later became the Alabama, I saw the Ernie Fields band out of Oklahoma, they were one of the well-known territory bands. Then at Sweet's of course, as I mentioned before, I saw Lunceford and Louis and all those fellas, as well as Glenn Miller. Then at the Oakland auditorium the Carolina Cotton Pickers — they may be named somewhere, I've seen their name somewhere in one of the books on big bands. The Carolina Cotton Pickers, as I mentioned before, the Andy Kirk band with Mary Lou Williams, she was playing piano at the time. And Ed Thigpen's father, Vin Thigpen, he was the drummer in the band. And Dick Williams, the tenor player, he and Mary Lou Williams were married. And the guy — he and Eubie Blake—

MR: Noble Sissle?

EW: Noble Sissle's band. I can't always — oh yeah, they were in their tuxes and everything. And of course the Duke's band. I saw the Duke's band at the auditorium.

MR: So would you be one — would you be on the dance floor or would you be one of those fellas that was like up —

EW: Front row. Oh yeah. I was married at the time. My ex-wife, ooh, she used to get uptight. She'd get so mad because she loved to dance. I'd be either up front of else in the wings where I could watch the drummers. And Sonny Greer, now, was the most underrated drummer. He never got any publicity. But he held that band together. He was a burner, I mean for drums. In later years, when you look for something else, and if you listen to the records, you'll find he's another fella that fit that Duke band like a glove. Like there was one tune called "Cotton Tail," which is a classic with Ben Webster. You know he made it really. But if you listen to the drums back there, and how he's kicking. And then when the band goes [scats] you just listen to what he's doing behind the band. And Ernie Royal, we were talking about Duke's band one time and talking about the drummers, because they used to talk about Hamp's band, see as I said before Marshall and Ernie and Vernon and Irvin Ashby, they were all in the first — Hamp's band, the first Lionel Hampton band that made "Flying Home." And Ernie said that they always had trouble with drummers. Because Lionel was a drummer, and he'd want them to play that heavy bass drum, and they'd wear out drummers. So he said, Sonny — one time Sonny Greer came in and they had to play a show and their drummer wasn't available. And Sonny Greer came in and he played the show so great and kicked that band so great that the owner of the nightclub wanted to hire him on the spot. Well naturally he couldn't because he was Duke's drummer.

MR: Yeah you don't raid Duke's band, do you?

EW: Oh man, no, no, man. But anyhow with that auditorium during the war, you have everybody that came through there. I saw Louis Jordan with his Tympani Five. Oh who the heck else? Well I named off quite a few, who's left?

MR: I'm curious if your parents were — did they feel good about you pursuing music as a career?

EW: Well it's kind of tragic in a way. See my mother and father, they're from Birmingham, Alabama. And my grandparents on his side, they own land, and they worked the land, and also from what I understand they would provide seed and fertilizer, and then the neighbors, they would all sharecrop and then they'd split the proceeds. And my dad, let's see I had three aunts and two uncles, and so my dad, they sent him to an industrial school in Tennessee, which later I guess became part of the school system, the college system down there. So he was the first one and I guess the only one in the family really that attended a university or a form of a university at that time. And my dad used to tell me

that he went to Handy — W.C. Handy's music store there in Nashville, Tennessee. Now my dad was born what, in the 1890s, so that had to be what, the early 1900s. He used to tell me that story. And my dad played ukulele and he sang and he would sing "Waiting for Ships that Never Come In" and they would do the recitations. Oh yeah. That's when people would visit. Because the big thing then was visiting in various homes and entertaining. And my mother — on my father's side my grandfather was a preacher. He was ordained. And so she had the chance, she was educated and played the piano. She was trained. You'd put the music up in front of her and she'd read it. So what happened, oh I was very young and my mother would try to get me to play the piano. But me, no. She was going to teach me. So I'd get down there, and fiddling, but no, I wanted to go out and play cowboys and Indians. I've kicked myself a million times. But what happened, my mother, when I was ten years old, she became ill and they took her to a hospital and she was in the hospital for two years. So then from twelve to fourteen she was at home. So there was really nobody to really do any encouraging. And then she passed away, see, so I was fourteen years old and my dad, he worked, and then he broke up the house and I was boarded out. So I can say that there was encouragement on my mother's side but I blew it. So after that, oh we kids would play. Several had a piano and when I'd go different friends we'd bang on the piano — "Chopsticks" — and just do a lot of foolish stuff. And one time I went to a teenage dance. And this was in the thirties, mid to late-thirties. And the WPA at that time, they had a music project. And they would send out different groups to play for the youth centers and oh, elderly, places for the elderly. So I went to this teenage dance and there they had a band. The WPA band. And the drummer was setting up and he had the foot, and the hi-hat going, and in the meantime he was putting stuff together. And I'm going how in the world can you do the different beats with each foot, separately but together? And he said, "Well what do you think? Do you think you could do that? Would you like to learn?" I said, "Sure." So he was a doorman on Pacific Heights with a split shift, and during his split he would come home, right there in the Western Addition. And I lived close to him. So he told me where he lived, told me to come by. So I went by and he put on his — he had an electric phonograph, so he puts on the Benny Goodman Trio, "Tea for Two," with Gene Krupa. And I listened. And so he said, "What do you think, do you think you could play to that record?" So I tried to keep the foot going and tried to get the sound that I heard Krupa doing. And he says, "Well maybe we can make something out of you." So that's what I would do. I would take lessons from him. And then I joined the union. Well what happened, then I would hang out — Vernon Alley and Eddie Alley, are two brothers here, they, along with Wesley Peoples, they formed a band. And so Wesley is a fine pianist. So he passed away so what they did, they got Saunders King to front the band because Saunders at that time had been

on the radio with a singing group and he had a bit of a name, so they got Saunders to front the band. And so anyhow I'd go by and watch the rehearsals and I'd watch the drummer, Maxey, Norville Maxey was the drummer. I'd watch him to see what he was doing. So then I found the name James Brown was forming a small band and he needed a drummer. Well in the meantime also, Mr. Thompson, our barber, he had been in the Cavalry I think back in the Midwest. And he'd been in the Cavalry band. So in his basement he had all these instruments and all this music. So he put together a small teenage band. And I played drums in the band. He got me in there, of course I couldn't read any music. So then when James Brown, the bass player, he had been a student of Vern Alley's, he formed a band and needed a drummer. So they recommended me. So I had to join the union.

MR: No kidding?

EW: Yeah. I'm seventeen. So what happened, our business agent then, see we were a subsidiary local. Our business agent lived in the area so they gave him my — they told him how to get in touch with me and he came by my house one day and said, "I understand you wanted to join the union?" "Yeah." So I said, "Well I don't have any money." He said, "Well how much do you have?" I said, "Well I've got five dollars." He said, "Give me the five dollars." So five dollars down, and every time I'd see him on the street if I had a couple of dollars in my pocket — so one day finally he said, "Okay, here's your ticket."

MR: And there was no like musical audition for that?

EW: No.

MR: Okay. It was kind of like by recommendation that they would let you in.

EW: Yes. Uh huh. And anyhow but in the meantime I'm down there watching all the drummers. Every time something would happen — as a matter of fact, going way back, before I became interested, back in the early thirties, it was during the depression, and not only did we have the Music Project but you had another project where they would send people, show business people, people that had stage experience, and they would send them around to the neighborhoods and I remember the house, there was a house on Sacramento Street with a large, it was a Victorian with a large dining room/living room. And so they would send this team out, a man and woman team out, and we teenagers would go up there and they'd teach us routines. We had the School Days routine, then we had another routine that we did, and then you'd rehearse and then you'd perform. So we had lines to speak and we had little dance routines, and also the Music Project would send a pianist to do that playing. And anyhow one of the times when our black veterans of war — the American Legion — they gave a program at the Veteran's Building here, the War Memorial building. And so the program was we youngsters, we'd do our skit and

then there would be a dance after that. So we did our skit and then the band, they were already set up and they came from the dressing room or wherever they were and they started to play for the dancing. It turned out to be the Fletcher Henderson orchestra. And now what am I, twelve years old? Thirteen years old? Something like that. Here's the Fletcher Henderson orchestra. Now the drummer's name was Pete Suggs — S-U-G-G-S. And I've seen his name on some of the personnel on some of the older records now. I don't know whether Roy and Ben Webster — Roy Eldridge and Ben Webster — were on that band or not, because I didn't know at that time. But they were with him. They were with Fletcher Henderson.

MR: Now did you know who the Fletcher Henderson orchestra was at that time?

EW: At that time? Not really. Not really. We had recordings at home — we had Paul Whiteman and Amos 'n Andy and the Two Black Crows and a bunch of other names. We may have had something by Fletcher Henderson because we had records. See my dad, being a chauffeur, the people were always giving him records, the people he worked for. So we may have had Fletcher Henderson records. I know that I became aware of him — oh it was after my mother died. I became aware of him because we had a station in Berkeley called KRE and it was the equivalent of our KCSM here or the K-Jazz that we used to have. They would play jazz records. Big band records. Small group records. They had one segment was the Moldy Fig segment where they'd play all Lu Watters at the time and they'd play old Muggsy and they'd play the traditional New Orleans stuff. And then they had another segment where they would play Lunceford, Kirk, Basie, Duke, Louis Jordan, the Savoy Sultans, there was another guy — what the heck, they did the song called "Who Threw the"— Doc Wheeler. With "Who Threw the Whiskey in the Well." Marvelous bands you know. And considering how crude the equipment was, gee, they were just marvelous. And the drums, of course you could hear the drums. I'd listen to those. But Fletcher Henderson, yeah. And when I really started getting hip to who he was I thought about how lucky I was, how I wish I'd been more on it, more hip, because I could have gotten their autographs. See when Harry James left Benny Goodman, in I guess the late thirties, he and Krupa both left, and they both played Sweet's Ballroom. Harry James played Sweet's and I went naturally, on the colored night, and there was the two singers you know. It wasn't Helen Forrest, she was with Artie Shaw at that time, she was a brunette. But there was a singer. I don't recall the name of the female singer, and there's this male singer looking at the audience trying to make eye contact, a real thin skinny cat, blue eyes. And I got his autograph. It was Frank Sinatra. He had just put out "All or Nothing at All." So there he is, just trying to make eye contact see? Because here was a whole colored crowd. And then Krupa, he came up here and he played at the bowling alley on Eddy and Jones Street. They promoted the public dancing there. But for

some reason or another it didn't last as a ballroom so they eventually turned it into a skating rink and the eventually back to a bowling alley. But Krupa went over to Sweet's. And he played Sweet's Ballroom just that one night, I mean two nights, and on the third night I was there and he did that "Wire Brush Stomp" which was a famous recording that he did, and at the end of it he threw the brush out in the audience. Unfortunately I didn't catch it. But he was another guy that was one of my idols.

MR: You probably have no way of knowing this, but do you think that bands would change their songlist from the white night to the colored night?

EW: That's a good question. Not going to the white night band, I think they played their recorded hits, whatever their records were. Because with Krupa, he just played everything he played. Well a lot of it had to do with tempo, see the dance tempo. A lot of it was that. And all the bands sounded good. Heck. Vaughn Monroe's band, they came into the T&D Theater and he had an excellent band. There was a sweet band. Alvino Rey, guitarist, he was with Horace Heidt who was the house band at the Golden Gate Theater for many years, and then when that band, Horace Heidt split, why Alvino Rey formed his own band and he came up from Los Angeles. He played the T&D Theater. They had a good band. I'm just trying to think of the other bands that I saw.

MR: Well let me ask you, the first time you made money playing the drums. Do you recall that?

EW: Oh yeah. Let's see. I guess it was with Patterson. Pat Patterson played the piano. And he was a good piano player, schooled in theory and harmony. And Pat used to get gigs at these after hour places so we worked at a place called Minnie's Can Do, up on Fillmore Street in the Western Addition, after hours, just piano and drums. And I think I made two bucks. And then there was a club called the Drum Club. And it was — the building is still there but it's under another name, that was right around the corner from the union, it was on Turk and Jones. And when Saunders King's band would get a job his drummer would take off and I'd sub for him. So that job I'd get I think one or two dollars. And the piano player was Rose Murphy. And I'd see her playing, and there would be a quarter, somebody put a quarter down there, and if I turned my head and looked back the quarter was gone. She'd steal the tips. She was an old timer you know.

MR: You didn't get anything by her I would guess.

EW: No. She would. She'd steal the tips.

MR: You were still a teenager, right?

EW: Yeah, and I had a little part time job. And I just wanted to play you know. I didn't — but for her I guess many times you had many performers and band leaders that they were, when it came to the money they were really tight fisted and a lot of times they would exploit their people. You've heard that story many times.

MR: Yeah I've heard Hamp was a little tight fisted.

EW: Yeah, well it was his wife, Gladys, because she wouldn't let him have any money because he'd go out on a drunk. One time, when Curtis was with the band, one of the times he said that they were always after Gladys. They said, "Gladys, it's embarrassing. We go out to a nightclub after we finish our dance engagement, and Hamp orders up, and he doesn't have any money to pay for it. Gee you've got to give him an allowance or something." So one day Hampton got a hold of one of the recording checks. And he disappeared for three days. And when he came back he was wearing the same clothes. He had gone out on a three day drunk. So Gladys said to him, "Now you see why I don't give him any money." So that's the story Curtis told.

MR: This is Curtis who?

EW: Lowe.

MR: Oh the baritone player.

EW: Yes. So he got with Lionel. Yeah that was a band. They always, the musicians loved to come to San Francisco. See he would come here and do the Golden Gate Theater, do their show there. He would do that, oh man he was a regular there. And the men loved to come to San Francisco because we had one of the highest theater scales. Yes. So when they'd come here they'd be downtown buying socks, underwear, shirts. Because when they were on the road they didn't make very much. Now Quincy Jones in his autobiography he mentions his stint with Lionel and he said they were making fifteen dollars a night. So I've forgotten the year he mentioned. But that wasn't very much money.

MR: Right. And sometimes you'd have to pay your own food.

EW: Well you did, you paid your own hotel, and your own restaurant. Yeah.

MR: I guess you'd have to want to play awful bad.

EW: Well music is like so many forms of art, it's a labor of love. And the music business, you talk about being addictive, it's as addictive as any narcotic man. I mean once you start playing, especially if you're playing with guys that can play and you get a certain cohesiveness and a certain satisfaction. And then the people, the audience, you bring so much joy to them. Husband and wife, or girlfriend and boyfriend, or fiancees, they'll come out and maybe that's a very memorable night to them. Maybe you played their favorite song and well they'll tell you what their song is and they go home with a pocketful of memories. And if you're lucky enough to have a CD or a recording or tape or something, they can take it home with them. And it's just — and without music and the arts, your culture has no soul, no soul. As a matter of fact you don't have any culture you know. So there's just a whole lot that goes with it, and so you just make the sacrifice. And I've been blessed because in the mid-sixties when rhythm & blues and rock & roll, well the early sixties when it started pushing us out, and our jazz clubs started to fold,

why I went to work for the union, in 1965. So I got a job with the union and so at least I could pay my rent and everything. So then I could afford to be a casual musician. So I would get casual work on the weekends, then I got most of my jobs, I was lucky, they were long term jobs. With Vernon Alley — I worked with Vernon Alley. He was the house band leader for the Black Hawk. And I worked with Vernon because we had been in the Navy together. I worked with him I guess maybe three or four years. Then when they started cutting back I got with Fatha Hines — well Scobey. I went with Scobey for a year and got the Dixieland experience. And then when Fatha Hines came here, the guy at the Club Hangover hired me to replace the drummer. I guess Hines was unhappy with the drummer. So that association lasted seven and a half years. So then after that then that was '63, '64 I worked with Slim Jenkins, I worked down at the Mars Club in San Jose. And then in early '64 Wilbert Baranco hired me to work two nights a week at the Claremont Hotel. He was doing five nights a week and he was up there — I was up there seven years with him.

MR: That's interesting because he's the first fella you recorded with, isn't he?

EW: Yes. In the Navy. And also in the mid-forties after the war Wilbert went to Los Angeles. See because he had lived there before and he knew all the musicians down there. They knew all the guys in the union. Curtis Mosby, you'll see his name in the annals, big band annals, Wilbert had been on the road with him, oh back in I guess the early thirties. Anyhow Wilbert went to Los Angeles. And as I said not only was he a fine pianist but he was a fine arranger. So Wilbert, he got in down there. He was working, he had a gig — a noontime gig, pianist/single; a cocktail session gig; and an evening gig, single; and then he was arranging. He was writing. He was selling his arrangements and he got a recording contract with Black & White. He got a date. And this is 1946. And he called me up from Los Angeles and asked me to come down there and do that date with him. So I hustled myself down to Los Angeles. I was working at the Band Box in Menlo Park at the time with Buddy Collette and Ernie Royal and a fella named Jimmy Shorter, a pianist, we had a quartet. So I got Bobby Alsbin to sub for me and I went down to Los Angeles. And we had to go out to the studio, out in Santa Monica. And I went to the studio. And here you have Dizzy Gillespie, Howard McGhee, Carl George, and another fella, I can't remember the fourth trumpet player. Then the trombones, I can't remember their names. Willie Smith on lead alto. Lucky Thompson on tenor. Then I can't remember the rest of the saxophone section. Mingus on the bass. And there I am sitting up there. And so we did several tunes for Black & White. And I understand now that some company in England I guess bought up the masters. And someone told me that they saw in one of the magazines this Wilbert Baranco recording with Dizzy on it, and of course I never got copies, never even heard them.

MR: Oh gosh. Never heard them.

EW: No.

MR: Wouldn't that be interesting now to hear it.

EW: So it was a wonderful experience. And when Buddy Collette and Ernie, eventually they went back to Los Angeles. See after the war I got a job in late '45, just as I was getting out the service, I got a job at the Band Box in Menlo Park working for Morrie Waxman. Now Morrie had had a club in San Francisco during the war called the International House. It was located on Columbus just across from the Barbary Coast — what was called the Barbary Coast, that was Pacific Avenue. And it was down in the basement, sawdust on the floor, big barrels for tables, small barrels for chairs. And they had a big bandstand. And I was in uniform and I worked there for him. And I used to do the extended drum solos and everything, and so I must have worked for him for six months. And we weren't supposed to you know, because the union had an agreement with the Twelfth Naval District that the union musicians wouldn't compete with the local musicians. But there weren't enough local musicians to fill all these jobs. Because you had — if you look in our Chronicle now you see all these little clubs. Well that's what we had during the war. Every little spot had something. Piano, piano and bass, piano drums guitar. Every little spot, all the North Beach, Chinatown, down Market Street, the Barbary Coast was wall to wall on each side of the street, clubs — bars and clubs. So I got that job down there playing, and it was good for me because I had the chance to work out these extended drum solos which later, during my course at St. Mary's College, because what I'd do you could hitchhike then, you didn't have to worry about transportation. So I'd hitchhike over to the International House and do my set, we played nine till two, then I'd hitchhike home, then I'd get up in the morning and we'd go out to St. Mary's and we'd practice all day and do our duties, our musical duties all day. So that was quite a period. Anyhow Morrie Waxman, after the war he moved down, he went down the peninsula and opened up this spot. And he hired us. We worked there for a year. Had Buddy Collette and Ernie Royal and as I say Jimmy Shorter. So that job, Buddy Colette was the first one back to Los Angeles and I got Curtis Lowe to play tenor to take his place. Then after a year, so Curtis, he must have come in, Buddy was there for most of the engagement. I think maybe the last two months Curtis played. And then I got Jimmy Shorter so he left. Jimmy Shorter, he was a railway mail clerk back in Washington, D.C. He was one of the first that they had. So he had taken a military leave so he said well it's time for me to go back. So I got Ali Mishaw, who had been the drummer for Scatman.

MR: Scatman Crothers?

EW: Scatman Crothers. An excellent pianist. So I got him, and so that association lasted — let's see we played, as I said Buddy was the first one to leave and then Jimmy Shorter, he went back to Washington, D.C., Buddy went back to Los Angeles, so that was Ernie and Curtis and Ali and I. And we got a job, we left there and we got a job at the Slim Jenkins in Oakland. He was quite the guy. The place was in West Oakland at that time. And it was a cabaret, I mean first class.

MR: What would your songlist have consisted of them? Kinds of tunes?

EW: Oh we would do bebop then. We'd were beboppers. We'd do "Now is the Time" and oh just Bird and Diz tunes.

MR: Really.

EW: And then of course, then as time went on we'd do ballads and we'd do standards, and when we went to Jenkins he had singers, so we'd back singers, so whatever the singer had we'd back it. And then of course since singing started to become popular so we would try to do some of the Nat King Cole things that he did at the time. [sings] Straighten up and fly right, you know. And we'd do well it was a mixed variety. And so then while we were at Jenkins we looked up in the audience and there was this guy with a trumpet in his hand and he came by and said, "Geez you guys I sure like what you do, geez I sure like what you do." So it turned out to be Kenny Dorham. His parents had sent him out here to clean up, because he was a—

MR: Oh yea.

EW: Yeah. So he used to come in to Jenkins to listen to us. So one time we did — Ernie knew who he was, I didn't. Because that was very, very early. But anyhow once we found out who he was then — I don't know how long he was here because we were at Jenkins maybe for about three months or maybe even longer. So then that job ended so then Ernie said, "Well, Earl, I think it's time for me to go back to Los Angeles." His brother Marshall was there and Marshall recorded with Eddie Heywood and traveled with Eddie Heywood's group, and Marshall was also with this — he played piano and arranged and was a vocal coach. He coached Lena Horne and Dorothy Dandridge and — it's on the tip of my tongue. Anyhow Marshall — so Ernie went back to Los Angeles. And sure enough, as soon as he got back to L.A. he started to work. He was with Kenton, then he got with Woody Herman and came up here with Woody's band and went all over the country with Woody. And he ended up in Europe. He settled in Europe for a while then he ended up in New York doing studio work and everything. But anyhow Ernie left and then there was just Curtis and I, so this is 194 — late '46, early '47. Oh by the way, during that period too, before we went to Jenkins, we played at the Swing Club in Oakland. Now that was a club on Lower Seventh Street It's now the site of the main post office. But that was quite a club there. They brought in Lionel Hampton, they brought in

John Kirby's small band, they brought in Jack McVea and they brought in Eckstine's big band with Art Blakey and all those cats and I got to see that. They brought in Fatha Hines and I'd go down there on a regular basis, never dreaming that someday that our paths would cross musically. But who was in that band: Wardell Gray was in the band, Kermit Scott, who you'll see on some of the early Billie Holiday records, Kermit Scott the tenor player. And they both left the band while it was here and so they got who else? That was the Fatha Hines band. But with the Eckstine band, I don't know how it happened but one day, I lived up there, and one of the times I went back and Miles was in the band. So I don't know whose place he took because I didn't know the personnel but I was just watching the band and watching Art Blakey. Because at that time you know, we had to watch him to see what he was doing. He was a powerhouse. And so anyhow then Hines' band came in and then Wardell left and Wardell — Vernon Alley put a little group together with Wardell in it and Gerald Wiggins. Yeah. Wiggins had gotten out of the service. Gerald Wiggins and Wyatt Ruther, Bull Ruther, the bass player. He was with everybody, Basie, Lena, Buddy Rich. It's easier to say who he wasn't with. Anyhow this was around 1947 so Vernon had put this group together. And so he had Wiggins and Wardell, himself, and who was on piano? He had — oh Wiggins. Wiggins was on piano. He had this quartet. And so they worked around here for a while then Wardell went to Los Angeles and he ended up with Benny Goodman, with Benny Goodman's bebop band.

MR: Oh right.

EW: Yeah, the one that had Doug Mettome and the piano player who later turned into a vocalist. I can't think of his name.

MR: I can't either.

EW: He had Charlie Kennedy on alto.

MR: That group didn't last too long, did it?

EW: No it didn't.

MR: It's funny you know if you think of Benny Goodman trying to go with the musical style. I mean he ended up—

EW: No he couldn't do it. But anyhow then Wardell, in 1955 Wardell, he was with the Benny Carter band. And the Benny Carter band, they opened up this mixed casino in Las Vegas. First time they'd ever had anything like that. It was — I've forgotten what they call it. Maybe it was The Flamingo, I can't remember. But it was a casino down there that catered to minorities. Because Vegas you know, it was very segregated. Strictly segregated. When Basie when there the guys had to come in the back door.

MR: And this is why he opened this?

EW: In 1955. In the middle of the year. So Benny Carter had the band there and one of our musicians here, Alan Smith, a very fine trumpet player who lives here, he was in the band. So they went down there and they opened up. Opening night after the gig they found Wardell out in the desert dead. So they don't know whether it was a drug deal gone awry or — to this day nobody knows what happened. But that just has to do with Wardell Gray. And by that time I was working with Bob Scobey. And we were in Chicago at the Blue Note. Now the Blue Note was quite famous in its day. They had 750 seating capacity and everybody played there: Basie, Kenton, everybody played here. And they brought Bob Scobey's band in in 1955. We went in in 1954 in October just for a two week engagement and opened — Sundays and Thursdays were off nights — so we opened on a Monday night, nobody; Tuesday night, nobody; Wednesday night, nobody. Friday night people were lined up around the block. And the first two or three days the girls, all the cocktail waitresses, they were grumbling you know.

MR: Yeah, no tips.

EW: And the place was swamped. And the second week, the same thing. Because people had heard Scobey's recordings, and it was the Frisco jazz, and it was strictly, well a little bit advanced from Turk, but they were like traditional — trad.

MR: Yeah, the traditional revival thing going on there.

EW: And a lot of the tunes I knew from a kid, having heard all that stuff on records. And then of course when I got with Scobey why I learned all those tunes, they were a snap, the transition was a snap. So anyhow that was October. So then we came back to San Francisco and so that following May we got a call again. They wanted us for a month. And during that month there was a woman who lived in Chicago who was an ex-showgirl from Seattle and Ernie Lewis the pianist, I got him the job with Scobey. He knew her, so one day we got a call from her says, "Come on ride out to the airport with me." "Oh yeah, okay." So we met her at her house, there were two cars, and they were loaded with showgirls. And we went to the airport in Chicago. They were going out to Vegas. They were going to be the showgirls for that casino out there. And it was all the talk in Chicago about this casino. Because you know the black community, we knew about the conditions in Vegas, in fact in the state of Nevada. So this was monumental. It was a big thing. So we got to see the girls off.

MR: That's great. I'm going to pause for minute. We're going to change tapes. If you don't mind talking a little more.

[break]

MR: The club in Vegas that you were talking about.

EW: Yes.

MR: Was it successful?

EW: It was successful for a while, very successful. As a matter of fact the different people from — see it was away from the Strip. See I was only there once. And I was there once. In 1955 when Scobey finished his engagement at the Basin Street in New York I guess — did I cover that?

MR: Yeah, I think so.

EW: We did the Basin Street with Bob Scobey's band in New York and we played opposite Gerry Mulligan and Chet Baker.

MR: That's an interesting combination of bands.

EW: Yeah, two separate. Mulligan had his group, Chet had his group. Oh boy it was ridiculous. The band leader — I mean the manager had to take him off the stand on intermissions and bring him back after intermissions, I don't know. He was just—

MR: He was kind of out of it you mean? Chet?

EW: I don't know what his story was. And Mulligan was all business. And George Duvivier was playing with Mulligan. So what happened, oh yeah that was the first week. The second week they had Calvin Jackson, the pianist. He had written for the studios and he was a fine arranger in Hollywood and then he went back up to Canada. He is a fine pianist. And then they had the little girl that played vibes with — her name was Terry something — she played vibes with—

MR: George Shearing maybe?

EW: No. The other — Terry, the other vibraphonist.

MR: Oh Terry Gibbs.

EW: Terry Gibbs, yeah. They did a duo at the Black Hawk. Anyhow that was the second week. But the first week okay, and then at the end of our second week there why George Duvivier, because Mulligan did the whole two weeks so George said, "Well I'm heading for the coast," he said, "I'm driving." He said, "Yeah," he says he had a '50 Cadillac with a '54 engine in it and he loved to drive. So I said, "Well I'll go with you. I'll send my drums ahead and I'll go with you." So anyhow we drove. That was 1955. So we drove cross country, hit Vegas, and he took me to this casino. It was the daytime of course. They weren't operating the show. But it was well known all over the country. And people from all over the country, minorities, they flocked there. And it was away from the Strip. People from here, from the Bay area, they would drive, they went down in droves, and all of them — it was that Vegas atmosphere and the shows. Lionel Hampton, Benny Carter, all the different bands that went through there. Then also Sinatra, when Basie was there naturally Sinatra was going to be there, all the stars and the movie stars and the entertainment people, they would end up there after they did their shows. They would end up at this — I'm not sure whether it was the Flamingo, but they would end up there and so the rumor I heard, I heard a rumor, somebody else told me now it's second-hand, that

what happened, the powers that be down there, the other casinos, the crowds would leave. So there was no action, you know, the slot machines and the gambling, it cut in on their action, so as a result I guess they somehow forced the closure.

MR: Yeah. I remember seeing a documentary about Vegas and I think you're correct, somehow that happened.

EW: Uh huh. They claimed that it was fantastic, said they had the best music and the best everything, dancers, comedians, but they had everybody: Flip Wilson, John Kirby, they'd have all — I guess I don't know about Richard Pryor, but they had all the best of everything, the best dancers and everything.

MR: That's very interesting. I wanted to ask you something you briefly touched on before. You were talking about rock & roll. You know musical styles and what's popular changes a lot but do you remember specifically what it felt like for jazz-based musicians around here when rock & roll started to take over?

EW: Well you know we've always had controversies with the musicians. The moldy figs against the beboppers. What did Louis say?

MR: Right.

EW: So there is always a controversy. I mean even if you read history in New Orleans, how there seemed to be controversies. You have the different schools. As I guess each age has its musical culture, musical taste, their fad, or whatever you want to call it. So I'm speaking for myself. I came up in the big band era. Then when bebop came in I was just fascinated with it, just absolutely fascinated with it. The improvisation, the tempos, the soloists, the independence that the drummers had. It was just fascinating. So then — we tolerated Dixieland, because you know we gave it its due, gave it the credit because it's improvisation, it's mainly improvisation. They had their songs and their routines, but then in the meantime the soloists, they improvised. And a guy like Sidney Bechet was way ahead of himself. Who knows? Bird might of taken from Bechet because he was a bad cat. Okay so you respect that. You listen to it. But then the doo wop came in. All these singing groups. Well the kids, the young kids, with disposable income, suddenly there was all of this money because the veterans, the veterans then and the war workers but mainly veterans, they were going to school, they were buying homes, raising families, and suddenly this surplus income, the money started to get tight. And here comes the young kids with their music and suddenly the club owners, you know the business is falling off. So some of them were jumping on the bandwagon. As a matter of fact in the mid-sixties I know when I went to work at the Oakland office they would have concerts, some of these promoters, they would promote a concert on the weekend. They'd have a garage band they'd draw eight, nine hundred kids. Well they'd pay the guys, what five men, four men, pay them $50, $75, not apiece, total. And if they charged a dollar on the

door and they got eight hundred kids, see I know over at the Lake Marriott Hotel, no not the Lake Marriott the – oh it wasn't the Lake Marriott, because they didn't have the public dances there — the Leamington Hotel in Oakland, they had a ballroom and the guys would promote dances. And we used to get calls from the management, "We'd like to know if you could tell us the band that played there. Our microphone disappeared," or, "part of our PA system is missing." Well these were all non-union groups, kids groups. So you know we had no way of knowing but then the Claremont Hotel up there, they decided, they got a young man and they gave him license to have concerts up there for the kids and they would draw, same thing, eight, nine hundred, a thousand people. But the kids, they were kind of rowdy. The cars that were parked, the cars would get trashed and they were just rowdy and the guests complained so they stopped that after a while. But in the meantime that was non-union activity, so that means that the union musicians don't get the gig, and then Bill Graham, he'd come into town and he started promoting over at the Fillmore auditorium. So he would do the same thing. He'd have a garage band. They'd have a lesser name plus a garage band. And $75 — "After all, man, you're getting a chance for exposure — exposure. This job is going to lead to" so and so. But then he'd have a semi-name, and then later he moved into Winterland. Then he started that, because they had a larger capacity. And then he became really big. And of course he opened up the thing down at I guess it's Shoreline, wherever that is down in Mountain View, that's really a big thing. But what it did, the club owners then suddenly they wanted singing groups and then with the rock & roll you'd have two guitars, electric bass, drums, and if they had a tenor player you'd have a guy, you had a tenor player sometimes, and what they would play, it was very, very loud music with a very simple harmonics structure, maybe three chords. So the club owners they just started hiring singing groups and those rhythm & blues and rock & roll groups. And for jazz it just pushed us out of the picture. And many of the big bands, they disbanded. Even Duke's band, there was an exodus out of his band with Johnny Hodges and Lawrence Brown and all those guys and they went out with Norman Granz. They had "Castle Rock." They had a hit record called "Castle Rock." See but they had left him. That band, they played the Black Hawk. Sonny Greer wasn't with them but the Lawrence Brown and Hodges, and I think Rudy Williams was on clarinet. And I don't know the bass player, drummer and piano. And Basie. Remember Basie had the small group?

MR: Sure, he had the small group in the fifties.

EW: With Clark Terry and Wardell and Buddy DeFranco and Sam Jones I think on bass.

MR: I think Jimmy Lewis played bass.

EW: Oh Jimmy Lewis, I beg your pardon, yeah Jimmy Lewis. And Basie of course and Gus Johnson. Yeah they played at the Champagne Supper Club here in San Francisco, small

group. So that's what it did with us. The big bands, they had to reduce. Woody Herman was out with a small group. Buddy Rich was out with a quintet. In '60, when we were in Chicago, he was playing in the room under our hotel. The Cloisters. We stayed at the Maryland Hotel. And they had a room called The Cloisters. Buddy Rich came in, Miles, he played at the Bird House but they stayed at the hotel. And Rahsaan Roland Kirk, they used to lead him around with all these horns around his neck, in 1960, before he made the big time. But that's what happened. Small groups. And even the singing groups, they had to lobby Congress to reduce that 20% entertainment tax. Because if they were singing then you had to pay entertainment tax. That was wartime tax. They taxed all entertainment.

MR: If there was singing they didn't have to pay?

EW: You did.

MR: You did.

EW: Did, yes. So they finally got the Congress to cut it five percent off, then they took another five percent off. And I don't know if they ever completely eliminated it or if you still have to pay a percentage, but that was also a deterrent. Because you couldn't — if the guy wanted to have jazz and the singers, so he could get both crowds, then that tax would kill him. So I hope I've answered your question.

MR: Well yeah and I guess it would be hardest on all the horn players.

EW: That's right.

MR: Because a rhythm section player could choose to say well all right I'm going to play with a doo wop group, but the horn players were like — they don't even have the opportunity.

EW: Well if you notice, like trombonists and trumpets, see saxophones sure, they could play the tenor and lay on their back.

MR: Walk the bar and all that stuff.

EW: Yeah. So it was a little detrimental and I just ignored them, I didn't even listen. Like all those tunes from the Doo Wop tunes, they're good tunes too. I can enjoy them now. But then they were just pushing us out of work. So I just, as far as I was concerned, and then some of them they didn't do the right chords or melody line. There was one group that sang [sings] I told every little star/just how sweet I think you are/why haven't I told you. Then on the bridge they completely screwed it up. They changed the bridge. So I guess they didn't know it. Because you know many times people, especially if you were playing by ear, the bridge is difficult. So you get to that middle part and you say uh oh. But that was just one of the things. And you'd listen to them and then say oh my God, they're mutilating the melody, the chord changes are so basic, and after you're listening — you know you're listening to Oscar Peterson and Bud Powell and Wynton Kelly — you're listening to all these guys and Shearing, oh. And so it's seemed so simple,

simplistic you know. And then when they started the Beatles, now the Beatles, when you study their music they are something else. They've got standards out. They've got tunes that you can play for anybody. "Michelle." [sings] Yesterday [scats] beautiful you know? "Norwegian Wood." Oh man. But then there's a lot of these other groups, but what they had, the mile high amplifiers and the roar of sound that practically knocks you over, and they're prancing on the stage, even breaking up instruments on the stage you know. So it depended on your musicianship you know. The more you know the tougher it is to go on. But then it makes money. See and your promoters, see the promoters, they could do more for jazz, because jazz is our American classical music see. But we can't get the support. We can't get the financial support that European classical music gets or that the things like the Rolling Stones. They draw. When they go out they draw such huge crowds. And the tickets cost a bundle. But see we can't get that kind of support. You can have a small following, people that come in, they enjoy what you do.

MR: Well you had, earlier on, before we were actually rolling, you had told me about the integration of the musicians' union. I'm not sure integration is the right word.

EW: Merge.

MR: Merging. And it's a fascinating story. And if you don't mind repeating it.

EW: Well sure. As a matter of fact I have some documentation that I can get to you. Curtis Lowe who was assistant to our Secretary/Treasurer, they commissioned him to document it, and he wrote a very, very nice documentation. It gives the local number of the first local, the first black local. And then he goes into the merger and it's very well put. He doesn't call names and stuff. But as I was saying before, see when I joined in 1937 the African-American black musicians, we had to join a Subsidiary Local. You got a card, Local 6 but Subsidiary across it. So that meant that you didn't have access to the building, you didn't have access to — well any of the services. But you were bound to observe their weighed scale working conditions. They had no vote in the election, and you had no representation on any committee — the wage scale committee — any of the committees. As a matter of fact at first when I joined we used to meet at the home of our Secretary/Treasurer/Business Agent. He had a room — well let me backtrack. When I first joined we met in Oakland at the Elks. But then it was when we became chartered in 1945 at 669 that we met at the Secretary/Treasurer's business office, I mean his home, he had a room downstairs. But we met in Oakland at the Elks, it was a black Elks over there. And the jobs — we had a Business Agent, we had a President, we had a Secretary, well Secretary, the Treasurer/Business Agent, he was all the same. Secretary/Treasurer/Business Agent. So we had an official family. And we didn't have a Board of Directors I don't think. No I don't think we had a Board of Directors. In '45 when we became chartered as 669 we had a Board of Directors. But anyhow as I was

saying, you had no say and also your employment was restricted. In San Francisco anything east of Divisidero the people wouldn't hire you. See they wouldn't hire. The club owners wouldn't hire, and I told you that story about the Dawn Club and Wilbert Baranco. And now that's the story that he told me. See he was directly involved. And now there was some isolated incidents, very isolated engagements where black musicians were hired. Eddie Alley, Vernon's brother, told me a story, he worked at a place on Pacific Avenue and it was gangster owned. And so they told the union, the union reps, "You leave this band alone. I want this band, and this is my club." So Eddie, he worked down on Pacific Avenue so that had to be in the very early thirties. And of course prior to that, see if you go back into the history about San Francisco and when we had Barbary Coast, the Barbary Coast was integrated. They had colored bands, you had colored entertainers, that was all down on Broadway and Pacific Avenue. There is a book written by a guy Jim Goggin and Sid Laprate is the name of the pianist that is mainly featured. As a matter of fact it's about Sid's history. And Sid — oh it's a marvelous book because it gives you the history going back to the — what do they call it? The Texas trot or something. The different dances that they did and what they used to do in the Barbary Coast and they were all colored bands. Kid Ory was even — he was out here in the early twenties. And I think Hines was out here, oh, he was out here in the twenties, I think the mid-twenties, before he became band leader at the Grand Terrace in Chicago. He was out here. But see but then I don't know whether it was the depression, but the city, we always had kind of like, there was racial segregation at all times, against the Chinese, against the Japanese, against the colored. Most restaurants wouldn't serve you. With us, if you wanted to go to a restaurant you went to a Japanese restaurant. If you wanted a hotel room you went to a Japanese hotel. See they would take care of you. And in Chinatown, you'd go there and they'd tell you you have to have a reservation. Unless it was a slow night. If there was nobody in the place then they'd let you in and put you in the corner and put a screen around you.

MR: Get out.

EW: Yeah. I experienced that. That's not just hearsay. That was my experience. And another experience, during World War II I was playing at the Stage Door Canteen, our St. Mary's band, Frasier Scott, one of our trombonists and I, we went out for a beer on intermission. And we went to this little, it was patterned after a cable car, a little bar, to get a beer on intermission. And in our uniforms, the uniform of our country, the bartender said, "If you want a drink you'll have to go out in the Fillmore." I said, "Well I'd like to see the manager please." Well the manager was trying to sneak out. And so we got him nailed and we said, "We're here in the uniform of our country and you won't serve us?" "Well, well." He stammered and stuttered, and anyhow we walked out. But there was a lot of —

in this town — I guess maybe after the gold rush, or I don't know when the color bar maybe got to be broader. But I can remember my experiences, even as a kid, they opened a miniature golf course on Fillmore and Sutter, right into Fillmore, right in the middle of the Western Addition, where most of the people lived. Miniature golf. And they wouldn't sell tickets to colored.

MR: That's, I mean—

EW: Insensitive.

MR: For moralistic of course it's terrible but from an economic standpoint it just seems silly. Why would they open it in the Western District as you said?

EW: Well the area was, see we were a minority. The black presence and the Japanese presence, we were very small see. Because you had Russian, French, Irish — the Irish mainly were out in the Mission District, but you had all kind of races here, and Caucasian. And so we were in a very small minority. So I guess either they figured they wouldn't miss it or maybe the white community might resent it. I don't know what the psychology was or the thinking was behind it. But that was a thing. But see so the same thing, after the Barbary Coast, because when I read the history of the Barbary Coast and I read about all these musicians that worked there and then they worked the dance halls on Market Street, they worked downtown Oakland in the dance halls. Now this is in the twenties. And then suddenly, in the thirties, everything is closed to black musicians. So I guess I haven't read enough about when he came about or why, but I just know that when I joined the union that you were restricted. Downtown Oakland had a business agent in that office before I got there and boy he'd do his best to keep the black musicians from working anywhere in downtown Oakland. And over here the same thing. We had a fellow named Eddie Burns and they would prowl and over in North Beach, he was Italian, Burns was his stage name, but they had great influence, even though I went to school with Italians over there at Galileo High School, the student body was largely Italian. But they just didn't hire you.

MR: So when this thing happened with the union, it was in '46 was it?

EW: Our merger. Yeah we merged. Now I drifted once again. I first started out talking about the black local and I told you the story about the merger, and then I joined in '37 in a Subsidiary. Well as I think I mentioned before, in '45 or around the mid-forties, Petrillo abolished the subsidiary locals. Because you had Subsidiary locals all throughout the United States. You had also black chartered locals and they had charters that went back to the early 1900's and some even the late 1800's in Chicago, 10-208, so I guess 208 was the black local. See when they merged many of them took the dual numbers. Like 10-208, that's the merger. They merged. But anyhow Petrillo abolished the subsidiaries and then as I mentioned before the Federation then gave the locals the choice of accepting the

subsidiaries as full members. Parent local they called it, or failing that, why that's how we came to have the charter of 669. So in 669 we set up, had our offices, we had a President, we had the Secretary/Treasurer/Business Agent and we had another office secretary and we had a Board of Directors. And I was on the Board of Directors. I got elected to the Board of Directors. And so we asked them on numerous occasions about amalgamation merger. Even one time we got it on the ballot through white friends. But it was defeated. So then as I said before the State of California, it's in the documentation I'm going to give you. And so anyhow after we merged Pop Kennedy was President at the time. And that was in 1960. And Pop Kennedy, he then proceeded to try to accommodate us as best he could considering that there was resentment from the hard core. So he appointed me to committees. I was on the Wage Scale Committee, I was on the Music Performance Trust Fund Committee. For five years I served on committees. Then an opening occurred in the Oakland branch office. They had this branch office that had been over there I guess since the earthquake. And so he put me in there and that's when I got my taste of musical bureaucracy. And by then too, your rock bands were really starting to flourish, in the mid-sixties. They were really starting to flourish. And over there then we had clubs opening up over there in Oakland. They would have these rock bands with all that noise. We'd be playing at the Claremont Hotel. That was during the same time I was working at the union. We'd be working in the lounge. Up over the lounge was what they called the Terrace Room. So they'd rent out the Terrace Room to a prom. The Terrace Room accommodated about 800 people. And we're down below here in the lounge. All of a sudden, crash, bam, thump thump. Noise. And the waitresses would go up and ask them could they please be quiet because they're disturbing the patrons below. And these kids, being kids, "Oh, we can't feel it if we don't play loud." So it was just terrible. But anyhow what happened, getting back to the union situation, so I worked in the Oakland office and then I got to learn you know, had to do wage scales and all sorts of different — give service to the members and collect the union dues and do the banking. Coming out of a jazz band.

MR: A steep learning curve.

EW: So Pop Kennedy passed away in 1967 then we had another president, kind of a weak president. Kennedy was a strong labor man. He knew all the delegates from our various labor councils and he was on the Executive Board of the American Federation of Musicians. He was a strong labor man. Then when he passed Al Arnold ascended. Al wasn't very assertive. And so then in 1972 we had another president Jerry Spain. He ascended to the presidency. He had gone to law school and he became president. Well he didn't like Oakland. Never did like Oakland. So he talked the Board of Directors into abolishing the Oakland office. They did it by Board resolution and then that same year,

election, they put it on the ballot to officially abolish the office, and put it up to a vote. And of course they voted, the membership voted to abolish the office. And that was very crucial and very damaging. Because we had about a third of our membership lived in the East Bay. And many of them held dual memberships. Local 424 was the Richmond Local, 510 was the San Leandro Local. And many of the fellas held dual membership. So they considered that Oakland office their office. They'd come in to pay their dues or just come in to gab. And when we had the elections — we had machine elections at that time — elections by machine. Now we have mail ballot. Anyhow during election time oh they'd set up in this particular building, they had a large room, almost like a ballroom, and they'd set up the voting booths and the fellas would come and it would be like a party. Because they'd be handshaking, just like a funeral the way the people gather, only it was very cheerful and convivial and all of that. And so they felt, man, you're taking away our office. So unfortunately many of them resigned. That was the beginning of the exodus out. And so now we're down to around about, tops, 3000 members. From 6,500 in 1965. So anyhow the office, they closed the office so then I ended up in San Francisco as an assistant to the Secretary/Treasurer. So I was over there from '72 until '94 I guess, and then another new administration came in and then they reduced the office staff. And so I ran for the Board of Directors. First time out I was elected. So this is my third two year term.

MR: When the merger happened, was it a positive thing immediately or at all?

EW: Well yes, on one hand it was positive. The 49er band, they got integrated. Because the 49ers, our football team, they were playing at Keesar Stadium then. That was out in the park. And they had a forty piece band and the band became integrated. And then of course by then, by 1960, many of the clubs like the Black Hawk, they were hiring traveling bands and local bands, and many of the clubs, they hired mixed bands. In a way you know you figure — Al Forbes, our Secretary/Treasurer/Business Agent, the one that took my five bucks — that was his dream. Because integration, even under Martin Luther King, integration they figured, that was the greater good. But for us well we lost our representation. We lost our official family. Our President, Secretary/Treasurer/Business Agent, the Board of Directors, that all went by the wayside you see. Also we lost our representation at the American Federation of Musicians' Conference, the conference they give every year, convention. In that way you lost representation and we've never been able to integrate the symphony. They have Asians, but we don't have any black people, African-Americans, in our symphony. The ballet we had a marvelous conductor, Denis deCoteau, but he passed away. The ballet orchestra — well we had Elaine Jones on tympani, she was in the symphony for a very short while. But then they claim that she didn't — her probationary period they claimed that she wasn't qualified. Now here's a

lady, she had gone to Juilliard, she had played all over Europe, and she played in the symphony, so they wouldn't let her — the probationary period. So Kurt Adler from the opera orchestra, he took her into the opera orchestra. So she played in the opera orchestra for years. And she went somewhere, I don't know where she went, whether she went back East or whether she went over to Europe. But she was a fine tympanist. But see tympani players, that's a high paid job in percussion because you have all the doubles. See you play all these doubles and each double means a little more money. So anyhow it's hard to tell because we also — see when the redevelopment came along we lost a lot of our black clubs. The employment that we had in the black establishments. The cabarets, night clubs. There was one time out in the Fillmore where you had a place called the Scene, you had Blackshear's Cafe Society, The Favorite Club, the Booker T. Washington Hotel, the California Theater Club, the Plantation, the New Orleans Swing Club, which later became the Champagne Supper Club, the Booker T. Washington Hotel, the Blue Mirror, the Ebony Plaza, then you had Bop City, the after hours spot, Jackson's Nook after hours, another place on McAlister after hours, I don't know what the name of it was but I went in there one night and Wes Montgomery was in there with his group. Then see the redevelopment, they destroyed all those. They just wiped them out. So we lost that employment see, and that was primarily black. Every now and then they'd have a mixed band. So I've been lucky see I can't complain. Because I've been very lucky. I worked with Scobey, I worked with Hines, and then the different groups I worked with, a lot of engagements were long term engagements. Here the one I'm on now at Scott's Seafood Restaurant at Jack London Square in Oakland, I've been on that job for Sunday mornings since 1986. And from that we get casuals — weddings and banquets and birthdays and all sorts — retirements, you name it see. So for me I've been lucky but some of our musicians weren't so lucky. See because you have some that specialize, you know specialize in certain type of music. That's why I say I'm lucky because I've been able to adapt to whatever the occasion calls for.

MR: Well of all the people you've played with over the years, is there one that stands out as a terrifically interesting character?

EW: Well Scobey was a very fine trumpet player. He loved Louis and Scobey of course had played classical music as well as jazz so his musicianship — he had excellent musicianship. He and Clancy Hayes. Clancy Hayes, oh man I think he was from Parsons, Kansas and so he knew all the Mississippi River lore. The first time I heard Scott Joplin's name it was from Clancy Hayes. Jack Brook, excellent trombonist, excellent musician. My Dixieland experience, they were good musicians and kind of like characters. Fatha Hines, now he was a legend, and I just couldn't believe it when I looked up and I'm on the same bandstand with him. And he was easy to work for because he just wanted you to

do your thing, play your part. And he would size you up and see what you could do, so I had an extended solo with the band. As a matter of fact I've got a record out, oh what the heck I've even forgotten what the name of it is.

MR: Is it the Monday Night thing?

EW: Yeah. I've got an extended solo on that. And so he was very interesting and he was a fantastic musician. Keys didn't mean anything, play in any key. He had a style. Now he wasn't really a bebopper but there was, at one time, one of his bands was loaded with beboppers. He had Bird, he had Diz, he had J.J. Johnson, he had all the beboppers in his band at one time. And they claim that was during the record ban, when they couldn't do any recordings.

MR: That's right it never got onto—

EW: So I was just reading somebody's book — his book — and it was talking about that band and what a great band it was. He said Jesus, everybody in there was full of arrangers and everybody was gung ho and everybody could play, and all he had to do — he had to learn as a matter of fact. But his mind was always open. He was always studying. If some piano player would come by and do something he'd go, "How'd you do that? What was that chord?" So he was very forward thinking and had amazing technique. I learned a lot when I went out on the road with him I learned a lot about the road because see when we went out with him he handled everything. Joe Glaser would do the booking but Hines would handle all the details. He'd see where we were going to stay, he'd see that — he'd book the hotel, the transportation, if we flew or if we took the train. Every week he'd pay us you know, took out the Social Security and all that stuff. He was interesting. Now when I worked with Vernon Alley that's when I really got a lot of exposure. We backed Flip Phillips, Flip Phillips came in as a single and so Vernon build a band around him. Let's see Jerome was in one band, I think Pony was in another, Pony Poindexter. Then Allen Smith was in another band. He was in both the bands that they build up when Flip came. And as a matter of fact we recorded that band. Richard Wyands on piano, Vernon on bass, I was on drums, Flip, Jerome and Alan. The first time they had a trombonist. I can't remember his name. He was from Vallejo. The second time we just had the three horns. He could play. Flip could play. Oh yeah. He could shout or he could milk a ballad. And then of course Stan Getz came through and we backed him. And he was easy to work with. He had certain things he wanted so you tried to accommodate him. Who else? Arthur Prysock was beautiful. We backed him. Oh what a voice.

MR: Smooth, huh?

EW: Dorothy Dandridge came in, she wasn't very happy. She cut her engagement short.

MR: Well you can't please absolutely everybody.

EW: I don't know what her problem was. We also — who else did we back? I'm just trying to think of who the heck else. Well Cal Tjader, he joined us for a while of course, and then for a while he had a trio at the Black Hawk so we had the two trios for a while and then when things started to get shaky and they cut his two men out and he played with us because Jerome left and Pony left. Pony left first, he went with Lionel Hampton. But he didn't last very long. Then Jerome went with Hamp and he eventually came back. But for a while there was just Vernon and Cal and Richard Wyands and I. And I'm just trying to think of who the heck — people would come sit in, see on Sundays we'd have a Sunday jam session. And people would come sit in. Now Howard Dedunne, Ed Thigpen, I guess that was during the Korean War, they were at Ft. Ord, they used to come up and sit in with us on Sundays. One Sunday Mel Lewis, he was with the Ray Anthony band, and they were playing the St. Francis Hotel. He came over and sat in with us, he and the bass player, I think his last name is — I remember he and the bass player, they both came over. He sat in with us. Tal Farlow, he was there with Red Norvo, and Red Mitchell. Mingus had been with them but he had left so Ray Mitchell. So Tal Farlow, he came in on a Sunday and sat in with us. Oh he played, oh what a good player. Then the Four Freshmen were at Thacks at one time, and Bob Flanigan, trombonist, he came in and sat in with us. And oh my God who else. Oh Jeez.

MR: Well you've just about done it all.

EW: Well I've been lucky. Just blessed, blessed. Then many times I get a break. The drummers would come in. Shelly Manne, Max came in, by then I had left, I was with Fatha Hines and I went down on the jam session, or went down on the performance night to see Max. Because hell he was the man. And a fella named George Morrow was playing bass with him, well George Morrow, we had played together with the Jerome Richardson quartet. See Jerome Richardson's quartet, see they started cutting back at the Black Hawk. That was in around 1953. And so they would just hire me just for Sundays only.

MR: I see.

EW: Or when a name came in and they wanted to augment the band. Maybe it was '52, '53. So I went to work with Jerome. Jerome Richardson. He had a little quartet and he was struggling so he did three or four nights maybe here or three or four nights there. So with Jerome we played a place called The Village in Richmond and we had George Morrow and Jerome and Cedrick Haywood on piano.

MR: Well you and I have something in common then.

EW: What's that?

MR: Two summers ago I recorded an album and Jerome Richardson played on it.

EW: Oh yeah.

MR: What a guy.

EW: That was before he passed.

MR: It might have been three summers now that I come to think of it.

EW: They had a memorial for him in New York and they had one here. And who should show up? Jackie Kelson showed up. The Basie band was laying over preparatory to going to Japan. So Jack Kelson, he came in, and Jerry Dodgion, he was in town with that band from New York, Carnegie Hall.

MR: Right.

EW: They were doing Concord so he played at Jerome's memorial. But getting back to this quartet, so we played the Village and then we came over here to San Francisco and we played, that was the Diamond Knee with Krupa. I was with the Jerome Richardson Quartet. And then we played at a place called the Cable Car Village, that's just at the foot of Nob Hill on California Street. And so we played opposite, they were bringing in different groups so we played opposite the Ink Spots.

MR: No kidding.

EW: Oh yeah. Oh what a good gig. And then they brought in Ella Mae Morse, and we backed her, and she loved the band. Because I knew all of her records, all of her records.

MR: That's so great, when you're listening to those records.

EW: "Cow Cow Boogie." Oh yeah. And then from there we went to the Champagne Supper Club down in the Western Addition. And so Hines came through, Jerome didn't tell me but Hines came through at the Hangover and his saxophone — when he left, Jerome left with him. And so I went to work the second week on the Champagne Supper Club and there was another band on the bandstand. Jerome had split town. And he hadn't told anybody. So anyhow that was my experience with the Jerome Richardson Quartet. It was a good quartet too. Jerome arranged, he did the arranging and the singing. He was extremely talented. And he played like the oddball horns, he played bassoon, oboe, English horn. Yeah he learned them all at the State Teacher's College.

MR: Right.

EW: Because in our Navy band he played the oboe. And he taught this other, Jimmy Shorter that I mentioned, the pianist from Washington, D.C., he taught him how to play the bassoon. A double reed instrument.

MR: Cool. Well Mr. Watkins, this has been fascinating. And we're going to wrap up here. And we probably, next time I come to town we could do Part Two.

EW: All right.

MR: It's really been amazing.

EW: Oh well, I have a tendency to drift.

MR: That's okay, you've got a lot of great stuff here.

EW: Somebody could edit the tape.

MR: We could move things around a little bit.

EW: Then we might get some good stuff.

MR: Well thank you so much for your time.

EW: Oh it's a pleasure.